

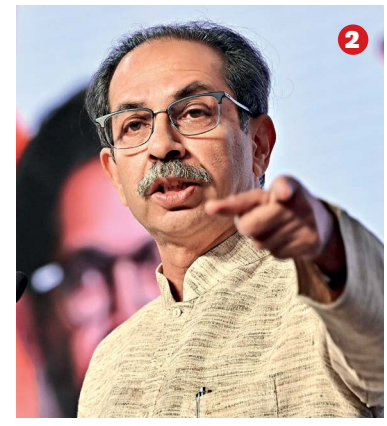
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IN DIRE STRAITS

1. AAP chief Arvind Kejriwal and Bhagwant Mann lead a rally in Kurukshetra, Mar. 10

2. Uddhav Thackeray at a Shiv Sena (UBT) event, Jan. 16

3. NCP (SP) chief Sharad Pawar in Mumbai, Feb. 15



HINDUSTAN TIMES

AAP'S GOING SOLO IN PUNJAB HAS MADE THE CONTEST QUADRANGULAR IN THE STATE; IN MAHARASHTRA, MVA PARTNERS HOPE TO TAP THE SYMPATHY WAVE POST THE BJP-ENGINEERED SPLITS



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and Vinod Yadav and chose to field candidates from EBC groups instead. The caste survey in Bihar last year had revealed that EBCs constituted 36 per cent of the state's population. However, the final tally of the I.N.D.I.A. bloc will depend on how well the Congress performs in the state. In the 2020 assembly election, it won only 19 of the 70 seats it contested; the RJD won 75 of the 144 seats it fought in.

I.N.D.I.A. VS I.N.D.I.A.

One of the most baffling developments within the I.N.D.I.A. bloc has been Mamata Banerjee's decision to not tie up with the Congress and the CPI(M) for the 42 states in West Bengal. The chief minister may have expressed vocal support for I.N.D.I.A. nationally but has fielded candidates against the alliance partners in the northeastern states too. She continues to tower over all other leaders from across parties in her state, despite the TMC being assailed by allegations of corruption, misappropriation of funds and atrocities against women by party workers in Sandeshkhali along with the arrest of some of her closest aides. So, it is around Mamata's image that the TMC's campaign strategy is centred, coupled with a slew of populist schemes, appeals to Bengali pride, declaring the BJP as a party of outsiders, accusing the Centre of treating Bengal unfairly in the release of central funds and a consolidation of the 27 per cent Muslim vote. The election in 2019 had come as a scare for Mamata as the BJP won 18 seats, reducing the TMC tally to 22 and becoming the principal opposition party in the state. The gap in their vote share too was an approximate three percentage points. Any surge in votes for the Congress-Left combination is likely to come at the TMC's cost. Mamata's move could also be a deliberate one to prevent anti-incumbency votes from pooling in favour of the BJP. But it's a ploy fraught with risk.

I.N.D.I.A. hopes for a modestly better haul in Delhi, Gujarat and Haryana where the Congress and the AAP have teamed up to avert a split in the non-